I never go on that balcony. It has a certain charm, just badly constructed. Two slabs of white stone pushed out carved with victorian patterns, too small to pace on, too narrow to forget where the edge is. The carvings along the sides are clogged with black dirt, the kind that’ s never been washed out. the railing is constructed of thin metal rods that form slightly crooked flower patterns. If you lean in too hard, it shifts a little, it’ s thinking about letting you go. It's more of a decoration than protection, something placed there to suggest safety rather than provide it.

I didn't choose this spot. It’ s where I ended up.

The apartment smells like something died but didn’ t have the decency to stay dead. My mother is cooking, or rather experimenting, insisting it tastes better than it smells, and I have never been certain of much but I am certain that it doesn’ t. It’ s thick and sour and rotting all at once, like it’ s sticking to the inside of my nose. I pull my shirt up over my face, coughing loudly every time I walk past her just to make a point.

I go to the window for air, push it open too hard, walk out, making sure the edges of my feet don’ t touch the growing black mold

There’ s a man on the street right below me, but that’ s too clean a sentence for what he is. He looks spilled out onto the gray and black cement tiles. His shirt has been ripped open, exposing a stretch of soft torso that feels wrong to

see, too soft, too colorless, like margarine. It doesn't feel like naked skin, not really, I think it's the last part of him that looks alive, still human. He’ s on his back, but not flat. Twisted slightly partially, like he tried to catch himself and missed. One arm is turned out, outward, palm open.

The first paramedic had dropped to his knees so quickly, hands on the center of the man’ s chest. Locked elbows. Straight back. He starts compressions immediately.

Hard.

Not the careful kind of touch you use on a person. This is different. This is pressure used as a tool.

Down.

The chest gives.

Up.

Down again.

Press. Release. Press.

It’ s fast. Faster than I expect. There’ s no pause to check, no hesitation, just a rhythm that overrides everything else. I wonder if he is singing *Pink Pony Club* or Staying Alive in his head to keep pumping at 120 bpm, he probably isn't.

Another paramedic is at the man’ s head. He tilts it back, clamps a mask over the mouth. There’ s a clear bag attached. He squeezes it and it balloons, then empties into the man.

Air pushed in. The chest rises a little, then gets crushed again under the next compression.

It’ s not breathing. It's the artificial shape of breathing.

A third one sticks pads onto his the onto the man’ s chest. Wires snake back to a machine. I can’ t see the screen, but I know what it’ s looking for.

Something that isn’ t there.

They stop.

Hands lift.

The man’ s body jumps. A sharp, quick jolt, like he’ s been yanked by something invisible.

Then nothing.

Back to it.

Press. Release. Press.

I don’ t notice my heart speeding up until it’ s already out of control. It pounds so hard it feels like it might shake loose from my ribs and drop over the balcony down to him, join (to join) the mess.

There’ s a woman next to him.

She’ s on the ground Just folded. One hand flat on the pavement, the other reaching for him, stopping just short of touching. Again and again. Like her hand doesn’ t trust the rest of her to jump into his twitching arms.

Her mouth is open wide. Too wide. She’ s shouting something. I can tell by the shape of it. But I can’ t hear anything.

That’ s the worst part.

The silence. It’ s like watching something underwater.

I grip the railing. It digs into my palms and I lean further than I should.

To my left, my brother is there. He’ s already leaning out, his whole body tipped forward like he’ s trying to get closer, We don’ t look at each other. We don’ t say anything.

What would we say?

More people gather below, forming a loose circle. No one gets too close. No one walks away. They just stand there, watching, like they’ ve are (like they are) tethered to the floor.

And then I look up.

Every window.

Every single one.

People in all of them.

Faces pressed to glass. Bodies leaning out. Some with phones in their hands but not using them. Some halfway through something else they forgot to finish.

No one moves.

Like we’ ve all agreed to this without knowing we did.

Maybe we think it will help him, all this staring.

Maybe the concept of someone's life ending before our eyes is the only thing that can stop the chaos of ours, of the unimportant things and tether us to our spots.